

Halignic Research Integration Series

LAKOTA / SIOUX SACRED TRADITIONS

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The People of the Plains -- Wakan Tanka and All My Relations

Mitakuye Oyasin.

All My Relations.

The rock. The river. The thunderstorm. You. All wakan. All related. All sacred.

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Lakota Sovereignty

The Lakota people have been clear and specific in distinguishing between what of their sacred tradition may be shared publicly and what is held as community-protected knowledge. The specific prayers of specific ceremonies, the specific content of vision quests, and the detailed ceremonial protocols of the most restricted ceremonies are not documented here. What is presented is what Lakota elders and cultural authorities have shared in public contexts -- including the extraordinary gift of Black Elk Speaks, the primary source for Lakota sacred tradition as lived experience, shared by the Oglala Lakota holy man Black Elk through his collaboration with John G. Neihardt.

Introduction -- The People of the Plains

The Lakota (whose name means "the friendly people" or "the allies") are the western division of the Great Sioux Nation -- the Tetonwan (Teton Sioux, "dwellers of the prairie") -- who occupy the western plains of North and South Dakota. Together with the Dakota and Nakota (the eastern and middle divisions), they form the Seven Council Fires (Oceti Sakowin). At their height in the mid-19th century, the Lakota were the most powerful military force on the Great Plains -- the people who defeated the United States Army at Little Bighorn (1876) in the most decisive Indigenous military victory in American history. But the Lakota are not primarily defined by their military history -- they are defined by Wakan Tanka, by the Sacred Pipe, by White Buffalo Calf Woman, by Mitakuye Oyasin.

The Lakota sacred tradition is one of the most sophisticated, most complete, and most living Indigenous sacred systems in North America -- a tradition that includes seven specific sacred rites given by White Buffalo Calf Woman, a specific understanding of the sacred dimension of all existence, and a specific sacred geography centered on the He Sapa (the Black Hills) that remains the most contested sacred land question in the United States.

The Emergence Story -- Wind Cave and the Origin of the People

Lakota oral tradition holds that the people did not originate on the surface of the earth but emerged from within it, through a passage now known as Wind Cave (Washun Niya, "breathing cave," or Maka Oniye, "the earth breathes") in the southern Black Hills of South Dakota. Before their emergence, the Lakota lived in Tunkan Tipi, the spirit lodge -- an underground world, waiting as the surface world above was prepared to receive them.

The emergence was led by Tokahe (the First Man). Along the way, the people stopped four times to rest and pray -- the origin, in this account, of the sacred significance of the number four throughout Lakota ceremonial life. When they emerged onto the surface, they found a buffalo hoofprint on the ground; the Creator instructed them to follow the buffalo, who would teach them everything they needed to know. The Wind Cave emergence story is the foundation of He Sapa's specific sacred significance -- the Black Hills are not merely territory the Lakota occupied. They are the literal birthplace of the Lakota people, the specific passage through which they entered the world.

Wakan Tanka -- The Great Mystery

Wakan Tanka (from Wakan -- sacred, holy, mysterious, beyond comprehension -- and Tanka -- great, large, extensive) is the supreme sacred principle of Lakota cosmology. The most common English translation is "Great Spirit" but this translation is inadequate -- it suggests a being, a personality, a specific divine entity in the Western theological sense. Wakan Tanka is more precisely the "Great Mystery" or the "Great Sacred Power": the quality of sacredness itself, so pervasive and so comprehensive that everything that exists participates in it.

"Everything that Wakan Tanka made is in some way wakan," Black Elk told John G. Neihardt. The rock in the sweat lodge is wakan. The pipe smoke is wakan. The buffalo is wakan. The thunderstorm is wakan. The human being is wakan. This is not pantheism in the philosophical sense -- the Lakota are not claiming that everything is God in a theological sense. They are making a specific, immediate, practical claim: that everything that exists has a sacred dimension, a mysterious interior life, a quality that exceeds its material appearance and demands respect.

Lakota theological thinking describes Wakan Tanka as having sixteen specific aspects -- eight superior beings (Wi the Sun, Skan the sky power, Maka the Earth, Inyan the stone -- the four most fundamental; and Hanwi the Moon, Tate the Wind, Iktomi the trickster, and Woose/White Buffalo Calf Woman -- the four that govern human life specifically) and eight associate beings. This sixteen-aspect framework is a systematic theology of how the one sacred mystery expresses itself through specific divine principles.

"At the center of the universe dwells Wakan Tanka, and that center is really everywhere, it is within each of us." -- Black Elk

HALIGRIC LENS: Wakan Tanka is the Lakota name for what the Haligric tradition holds about the sacred dimension of all existence -- not as a philosophical position but as the specific, immediate, practical recognition that everything the practitioner encounters in any moment carries a sacred interior that demands acknowledgment. The practitioner who approaches a rock, a river, a meal, a difficult person with the specific awareness that they are encountering something wakan is doing Lakota sacred practice whether they know it or not.

The Wakan Beings -- The Wider Spirit World

Beyond Wakan Tanka as an encompassing sacred mystery, Lakota cosmology recognizes a populated spirit world -- beings holding wakan power in varying degree and character, some benevolent, some dangerous, all worthy of respect.

Wakinyan -- The Thunder Beings

The Wakinyan, or Thunderbirds, are great winged beings who produce thunder with their wingbeats and lightning from their eyes -- so wrapped in cloud that their true form is never clearly seen. Generally protective of the people, the Wakinyan are the eternal adversaries of the Unktehi, water monsters said to cause floods. A person who dreams of the Wakinyan may become heyoka -- a sacred clown or contrary, someone who lives and acts in reversed fashion (laughing at sorrow, dressing for winter in summer) as a mark of this specific spiritual calling, and who holds healing power and the ability to interpret dreams.

Iktomi -- The Trickster

Iktomi, the spider, is the Lakota trickster figure -- clever, unpredictable, and prone to mischief that as often ensnares him as it does his intended targets. Iktomi is credited with giving humans the power of speech. Stories of Iktomi function as moral instruction as much as entertainment -- his schemes typically illustrate, by negative example, the behaviors right living requires people to avoid.

Inyan (Stone) is described in some tellings as the primordial, sourceless being from whom all else descended: lonely, Inyan gave of his own substance to create Maka (Earth), draining his fluid essence into the world's waters and leaving him hardened into rock. Other beings hold specific domains: Tate the wind; Wi the sun; Hanwi the moon; Waziya, the giant of the north who brings winter cold.

Oceti Sakowin -- The Seven Council Fires and Lakota Social Structure

The people commonly known by the exonym "Sioux" call themselves Oceti Sakowin -- the Seven Council Fires -- an alliance of seven related divisions speaking three closely related dialects: Dakota, Nakota, and Lakota. The Lakota are the westernmost and historically the youngest of the seven fires, having pushed furthest onto the Plains as buffalo-hunting, horse-mounted people.

The basic unit of traditional Lakota society was the tiyospaye -- an extended family camp made up of multiple tiwahe (immediate families) joined by blood, marriage, adoption, and ongoing mutual obligation. Several tiyospaye together formed a band (such as the Oglala or Sicangu). Leadership was neither hereditary nor rigidly hierarchical -- authority rested on demonstrated courage and skill rather than birthright. Councils of elders and recognized peace-oriented leaders (itancan) mediated disputes and guided major decisions by consensus.

He Sapa -- The Sacred Black Hills

He Sapa ("Black Ridge" or "Black Hills") is the sacred center of the Lakota universe -- the specific landscape from which the Lakota people emerged (Wind Cave), the place where White Buffalo Calf Woman is understood to have brought the Sacred Pipe to the people, and the heart of the entire Lakota sacred geography. The seven sacred sites of He Sapa are understood to be aligned with the pattern of the stars. He Sapa is not merely territory -- it is, as Lakota elders consistently describe it, "the heart of everything that is."

The 1868 Fort Laramie Treaty formally recognized He Sapa as belonging to the Oceti Sakowin -- "for the absolute and undisturbed use and occupation of the Sioux." In 1874, Lieutenant Colonel George Armstrong Custer led a military expedition that confirmed the presence of gold, triggering a settler flood into treaty-protected territory. Congress effectively confiscated the Black Hills in 1877. The Lakota have refused to accept compensation for He Sapa since the US Supreme Court ordered \$102 million in 1980 -- a sum that has grown to nearly \$2 billion, sitting uncollected in the US Treasury. The Lakota position is unequivocal and has never wavered: the Black Hills are not for sale. The land itself must be returned.

Mount Rushmore -- the colossal carving of four US presidents into what the Lakota call "Six Grandfathers" -- stands within He Sapa as an ongoing symbol of desecration. A young Lakota activist described it: "It's like someone carving their face into the Vatican, or Mecca. It's an act of spiritual violence."

Contemporary developments: In November 2024, tribal representatives from Standing Rock, Oglala, Rosebud, and Cheyenne River gathered to draft the Sacred He Sapa Restoration Act, seeking formal return of federal land in the Black Hills to the Oceti Sakowin -- proposed for introduction in 2025. In December 2024, outgoing Interior Secretary Deb Haaland delivered a 20-year ban on new mining claims around Pactola Reservoir and the Rapid Creek watershed, protecting more than 20,500 acres. The Pe'Sla site -- a sacred high meadow described in oral tradition as the place "where the Morning Star came down to help the people" -- remains the subject of ongoing legal battles against proposed exploratory drilling.

HALIGRIC LENS: He Sapa is the most politically active sacred geography in this library. The Lakota are not maintaining a historical relationship with a landscape that was once sacred -- they are actively fighting, in courts and legislatures and at the land itself, to maintain and restore a sacred relationship that is fully alive and fully present. The \$2 billion sitting uncollected in the US Treasury is among the most powerful single facts about the nature of the Lakota people's relationship with their sacred land. They will not take the money. The land is not something that can be compensated for. It is the origin of the people.

White Buffalo Calf Woman -- The Complete Story and the Sacred Pipe

White Buffalo Calf Woman (Ptesan-Wi or Ptehinčala Ska Win) is the most important sacred being in Lakota tradition -- the divine female figure who appeared to the Lakota people in a time of great spiritual and material need, who gave them the Sacred Pipe (čhanunpa) and the Seven Sacred Rites, and who transformed into a white buffalo calf as she departed.

The Complete Story

The Appearance: At a time when the Lakota people were struggling, two scouts were sent out to find game. They saw a beautiful woman approaching across the prairie, dressed in white buckskin. One scout looked at her with desire -- he immediately turned to bones and dust, destroyed by the power he had disrespected. The other scout recognized her as a sacred being and approached with reverence. She told him to return to his people and prepare for her arrival.

The Gift of the Pipe: White Buffalo Calf Woman walked into the camp carrying a bundle wrapped in buffalo hide. Inside was the Sacred Pipe. She showed the people how to hold it (the stem representing all living things; the bowl representing Ina Maka, the Earth; the tobacco representing gratitude), how to fill it with sacred tobacco, how to smoke it in prayer. She taught them that through the Pipe, their prayers would rise directly to Wakan Tanka.

The Departure and Transformation: White Buffalo Calf Woman walked backward away from the camp, pausing four times. At the first pause she became a young red-and-brown buffalo. At the second she became a white buffalo. At the third she became a black buffalo. At the fourth she rolled on the ground and disappeared over a hill. The birth of white buffalo calves -- extremely rare genetic events -- is understood by the Lakota as the return of White Buffalo Calf Woman's presence. The birth of Miracle, a white buffalo calf, in Wisconsin in 1994 drew Lakota elders and was treated as a sacred event of the highest significance.

The Sacred Pipe (Chanunpa) -- The Most Sacred Object

The Chanunpa (Sacred Pipe) is the central sacred object of Lakota tradition -- the physical gift White Buffalo Calf Woman brought to the people, and the instrument through which every ceremony in this document is conducted. Without the Pipe, none of the Seven Sacred Rites can properly begin.

The Pipe has two parts, kept separate except during ceremony -- the stem (wooden, often ash, representing all growing, living things and the masculine principle) and the bowl (traditionally carved from catlinite, the red pipestone quarried at a single sacred site in present-day Minnesota, representing the earth, Ina Maka, and the feminine principle). Joining the stem to the bowl at the start of ceremony is itself a sacred act -- the union of the two principles. The red stone carries its own sacred narrative: the Lakota hold that the pipestone quarry is colored red by the blood of ancestors, and that the site is sacred ground belonging to no single nation -- traditionally, even enemies could quarry there together in peace. The Pipe is filled with chansasha (kinnikinnick -- traditionally a mixture of tobacco with red willow bark and other plant matter). Filling the Pipe is itself part of the ceremony -- each pinch of tobacco placed with a specific prayer, addressing one of the four directions, the earth, and the sky in turn.

Pipe Ceremony -- Step-by-Step

Step 1 -- The Gathering: Participants sit in a circle, traditionally with the Pipe carrier facing the direction the ceremony calls for. The circle itself is significant -- no head of the table, no hierarchy of position, everyone equally present.

Step 2 -- Filling the Pipe: The bowl and stem are joined. The leader fills the Pipe with chansasha, pinch by pinch, offering each pinch first to the west, then north, east, south, then to the sky above and the earth below -- the six directions -- with a specific prayer accompanying each.

Step 3 -- The Lighting: The Pipe is lit, traditionally with a coal from a sacred fire. The leader draws the first smoke and offers it again to the six directions before it is passed.

Step 4 -- The Passing: The Pipe is passed sunwise (clockwise) around the circle. Each participant may offer a brief prayer before smoking and passing. No one refuses the Pipe once it is offered -- to do so is to refuse the relationship and the prayer itself.

Step 5 -- The Prayers Rise: As the smoke rises, it is understood to carry the prayers of everyone present directly to Wakan Tanka -- the smoke is the visible form of the prayer's ascent.

Step 6 -- The Emptying and Closing: When the Pipe has gone fully around, the ashes are emptied onto the earth, returning what remains to Ina Maka. The Pipe is disassembled and the ceremony closes, often with "Mitakuye Oyasin" spoken together.

The Pipe Ceremony is rarely conducted in isolation -- it opens the Sweat Lodge, precedes the Vision Quest, and punctuates the Sun Dance at morning and evening. It is the connective tissue that makes the other sacred rites possible.

The Seven Sacred Rites -- Overview

White Buffalo Calf Woman gave the Lakota seven specific ceremonies, each addressing a distinct dimension of human and communal life. Together they form a complete ceremonial architecture -- not seven unrelated rituals but seven facets of a single sacred system.

1. Inipi (the Sweat Lodge) -- purification; the foundation ceremony that precedes nearly all the others. 2. Hanblecheyapi (the Vision Quest) -- the individual's direct encounter with the sacred in isolation, seeking specific guidance for their life's direction. 3. Wiwanyang Wachipi (the Sun Dance) -- the collective ceremony of communal renewal and personal sacrifice for the people. 4. Wanagi Yuhapi (Keeping of the Soul) -- the ceremony that honors a deceased person's spirit for up to a year before its final release. 5. Hunkapi (Making of Relatives) -- the ceremony that creates a permanent, sacred kinship bond between people who are not blood relatives. 6. Isnathi Awichalowan (Coming of Age for Women) -- the ceremony marking a young woman's first menstruation and her formal recognition as a woman with specific sacred responsibilities. 7. Tapa Wankayeyapi (Throwing of the Ball) -- conducted for a young child, the ball representing the world and all knowledge thrown to the four directions. The Seven Rites cover purification, individual vision, collective sacrifice, death and grief, chosen kinship, the passage into adulthood, and the blessing of a new life -- a complete ceremonial map of a human life within the Lakota sacred world.

Inipi -- The Sweat Lodge, Complete Step-by-Step

The Inipi (from ini, "life energy," and pi, indicating a ceremony) is the most widely conducted of the Seven Sacred Rites -- the purification ceremony that is the foundation for all other sacred practice. It is conducted before the Vision Quest, before major decisions, and as a regular practice of spiritual and physical renewal. The dome-shaped framework of willow branches represents the womb of Ina Maka (the Earth Mother); the lodge is the place of renewal and rebirth. The entrance faces west -- the direction of the setting sun and the spirit world. The heated rocks (the Grandfathers and Grandmothers) are addressed as living relatives.

Step 1 -- Pipe Ceremony Opening: The ceremony leader opens with the Sacred Pipe -- offering smoke to the six directions and to Wakan Tanka.

Step 2 -- Entering the Lodge: Participants enter clockwise, crawling through the low entrance. Each participant says "Mitakuye Oyasin" (All My Relations) as they enter -- the declaration that opens the heart to the ceremony.

Step 3 -- The First Round: The first seven heated rocks are brought in -- each carried on a pitchfork, never touched by human hands. As each rock enters, it is addressed: "Welcome, Grandfather." Sacred herbs (sage, sweet grass, cedar) may be placed on the rocks.

Step 4 -- The Door Closes: The lodge flap is lowered, sealing the space in total darkness. The heat and darkness together create the conditions of the womb -- the practitioner returning to the state of before-birth.

Step 5 -- Water and Prayers: The leader ladles water over the rocks -- steam fills the lodge. The leader prays aloud. Participants may pray aloud or silently. Songs specific to the ceremony may be sung.

Step 6 -- The Four Rounds: A full sweat lodge has four rounds, each with additional rocks. Round 1: Purification and addressing the sacred beings. Round 2: Personal prayers and the release of what needs to be released. Round 3: Healing -- for self and for those prayed for. Round 4: Gratitude and the closing of the sacred work.

Step 7 -- Mitakuye Oyasin: At the end of each round, "Mitakuye Oyasin" is spoken and the flap is opened briefly, allowing fresh air.

Step 8 -- The Emergence: At the ceremony's end, each participant emerges on hands and knees -- born again from the dark, hot womb into the air and light.

Step 9 -- Pipe Closing: The ceremony closes with the pipe -- the final smoke offering sealing the ceremony and the gratitude.

Wicozani and Wolakota -- Holistic Wellness and the Path to Balance

Wicozani -- complete health and wellbeing, encompassing physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual dimensions together -- is the Lakota concept of true wellness, achieved and maintained through wolakota, a state of balance and harmony among a person, their community, and the whole of creation. These remain the explicit foundation of contemporary Lakota-run health and healing programs across the reservations.

Lakota tradition distinguishes between two kinds of healers. The pejuta wicasa (medicine person -- one who works with pejuta, medicine/herbs) treats physical ailments using plant knowledge passed down through careful apprenticeship. The wicasa wakan (holy man) or winyan wakan (holy woman) works at the level of spirit -- diagnosing illness understood to arise from imbalance or spiritual disharmony, and treating it through vision, prayer, and ceremony. A person becomes a wicasa wakan not through simple training but through a specific calling -- often a vision or a formative illness in youth -- followed by rigorous mentorship.

Wocekiye -- commonly translated "prayer," though its deeper meaning is closer to the active acknowledgment and honoring of one's relatives, human and non-human alike -- is the daily practice through which wicozani is pursued and renewed. Seven virtues, understood to have been given alongside the sacred pipe by White Buffalo Calf Woman, structure this practice: wocekiye (prayer), wowacintanka (fortitude), wawoohola (respect), waunsilapi (compassion), wowicake (truth), woksape (wisdom), and cantognake (generosity of heart).

Hanblecheyapi -- The Vision Quest, Complete Step-by-Step

Hanblecheyapi ("crying for a vision") is the individual counterpart to the collective Sun Dance -- the ceremony through which a person seeks direct, personal contact with the

sacred in complete isolation, fasting, and exposure to the elements, in order to receive guidance for their life's path.

Step 1 -- The Approach: A person seeking a vision approaches a respected medicine person or holy man qualified to guide one -- this approach is itself formal, often accompanied by an offering of tobacco.

Step 2 -- Purification: The seeker undergoes Inipi in the days before the quest, purifying body and mind in preparation for the isolation to come.

Step 3 -- Preparation of the Site: A hilltop or other isolated, elevated place is chosen and prepared -- often marked with prayer ties (small bundles of tobacco wrapped in cloth, colored to the four directions).

Step 4 -- The Isolation: The seeker is left alone for one to four days and nights, without food or water, exposed to whatever weather comes. They remain within the marked boundary, praying continuously, watching for a vision.

Step 5 -- The Holy Person's Watch: The guiding holy person remains nearby, though out of sight, monitoring the seeker's wellbeing and periodically conducting ceremony on the seeker's behalf.

Step 6 -- The Return: At the end of the fast, the seeker is brought down, given water and food carefully, and undergoes another Inipi to mark the transition back to ordinary life.

Step 7 -- Interpretation: The seeker shares what came to them with the holy person, who helps interpret its meaning. A vision may shape a person's name, their life's work, or a specific responsibility they carry forward.

Wiwanyang Wachipi -- The Sun Dance, Step-by-Step

The Sun Dance (Wiwanyang Wachipi -- "gazing at the sun while dancing") is the most important of the Seven Sacred Rites and one of the most physically demanding and most spiritually concentrated ceremonies in any tradition anywhere. It is a four-day ceremony of collective renewal, personal sacrifice for the community, and the specific renewal of the relationship between the Lakota people and the Creator -- conducted annually in late June or July.

The Sun Dance was prohibited by the US government in 1883 and remained legally suppressed until the American Indian Religious Freedom Act of 1978. The fact that it was maintained in secret through 95 years of legal suppression is one of the most extraordinary examples of ceremonial survival in any tradition. At the center of the Sun Dance circle stands the sacred cottonwood tree (the Sun Dance pole) -- selected, prayed over, cut down with specific ceremony, carried to the dance ground without touching the earth, and raised as the axis mundi of the ceremony.

Step 1 -- Sweat Lodge Preparation: Each dancer undergoes Inipi before the ceremony begins.

Step 2 -- Raising of the Tree: The sacred cottonwood is raised with specific ceremony and prayer -- the four days of dancing organized around this axis between earth and sky.

Step 3 -- The Four Days of Dancing: Dancers fast from food and water, dance continuously from dawn to dusk facing the sun, and offer their suffering as prayer for the healing of their community. The suffering is not incidental to the prayer -- it IS the prayer.

Step 4 -- The Pipe Ceremony: Morning and evening, the pipe is smoked -- maintaining the specific connection between the human prayer and the divine recipient.

The Piercing: In the most traditional form, some dancers are pierced -- skewers passed through the skin of the chest or back, attached by ropes to the central pole. The dancers move backward until the skin tears and they are released. This voluntary sacrifice of flesh is the dancer's ultimate gift to the people -- the flesh offered so that the community may be healed and renewed. The piercing is always voluntary.

Step 5 -- The Completion: At the ceremony's end, the dancers are honored by the community -- they have sacrificed for everyone present, and their sacrifice is acknowledged as a gift to all.

Wanagi Yuhapi -- Keeping of the Soul

Wanagi Yuhapi (Keeping of the Soul) is the Lakota tradition's ceremony for grief and the dead -- in which a deceased person's soul is formally kept, honored, and cared for by a designated relative for up to a year before being ceremonially released.

Step 1 -- Taking the Soul: At the time of death, a lock of the deceased's hair is cut and kept -- understood to hold the person's soul (wanagi) in a form that can be cared for.

Step 2 -- The Soul Bundle: The lock of hair is wrapped and kept in a specially prepared bundle, treated with the same care and respect as a living relative -- placed in a position of honor within the keeper's home.

Step 3 -- The Period of Keeping: For up to a year, the keeper maintains the bundle, offering it food at meals, speaking to it, and observing specific behavioral restrictions as an act of ongoing relationship with the departed soul.

Step 4 -- Community Support: During the keeping period, the keeper's extended family and community provide material support -- the keeper's obligations to the soul bundle take precedence over ordinary daily labor.

Step 5 -- The Release Ceremony: A formal ceremony releases the soul -- the bundle is given away, along with a significant giveaway of the keeper's possessions to the community.

Step 6 -- The Giveaway: The distribution of goods at the release ceremony is the culminating act -- grief, properly kept and released, produces generosity rather than depletion.

Hunkapi -- Making of Relatives

Hunkapi (Making of Relatives) is the ceremony through which the Lakota create kinship bonds between people who are not related by blood -- a formal, sacred adoption that carries the same binding obligations as birth relationship. It is the clearest ceremonial expression of Mitakuye Oyasin as a practice rather than only a saying.

Step 1 -- The Request: A person or family wishing to formally adopt someone as a relative approaches a holy person qualified to conduct the ceremony.

Step 2-3 -- Preparation and Ceremony: Specific ceremonial objects are prepared. The holy person conducts the rite joining the two people as relatives -- involving prayer, the Sacred Pipe, and specific ceremonial acts that formally declare the kinship before the community.

Step 4-5 -- Exchange and Feast: Significant gifts are exchanged publicly. A community feast follows, at which the new relationship is announced and celebrated -- the community as a whole becoming witness to the new kinship bond.

Step 6 -- The Ongoing Obligation: From that point forward, the made relative carries the full weight of kinship obligation -- the same responsibilities and the same claims on mutual support as a relative by blood.

Isnathi Awichalowan -- Coming of Age for Women

Isnathi Awichalowan (Coming of Age for Women) marks a young woman's first menstruation and her formal recognition by the community as a woman carrying specific sacred responsibilities -- one of the Seven Sacred Rites and the tradition's primary ceremony honoring female maturity as a sacred, not merely biological, transition.

Step 1 -- The Announcement: When a young woman experiences her first menstruation, her family begins preparation for a formal ceremony.

Step 2-3 -- Seclusion and Instruction: The young woman spends a period in a specially prepared space, during which elder women teach the specific skills, values, and sacred understanding she will need -- including her connection to White Buffalo Calf Woman as the source of Lakota womanhood's sacred authority.

Step 4-6 -- Ceremony, Giveaway, and Recognition: A formal ceremony marks her emergence as a recognized woman of the community, followed by gifts distributed to the community and a celebratory feast.

Tapa Wankayeyapi -- Throwing of the Ball

Tapa Wankayeyapi (Throwing of the Ball) is the Sacred Rite conducted for a young child -- in which a ball, representing the world and the whole of sacred knowledge, is ceremonially thrown to the four directions and to the sky and earth, symbolizing the child's life path and the community's hope that she will have the opportunity to gain complete sacred knowledge in her lifetime.

Steps 1-5: A ball specially made from buffalo hide stuffed with buffalo hair is thrown in turn to the west, north, east, and south -- completing the circuit of the four directions, each throw accompanied by prayer for the child's growth. The ball is then thrown upward and offered toward the earth -- completing the six directions and symbolically offering the child's full life to the sacred world.

The ceremony expresses the community's hope that the child, over her lifetime, will have the chance to receive the fullness of sacred knowledge -- that her life will not be cut short or foreclosed, but will have the opportunity to travel the whole circle the ball's throw represents.

Contemporary Lakota -- Sacred Continuity and the Living Struggle

The Lakota sacred tradition is not museum-piece religion. The Sacred Pipe is still lit. The sweat lodges still run. The Sun Dance -- suppressed by law for 95 years -- returned when the American Indian Religious Freedom Act was signed in 1978, and the practitioners had not lost a single year of practice. Black Elk Peak (formerly Harney Peak, renamed in 2016 to honor the Oglala holy man) rises from He Sapa, still a site of vision quests and ceremony.

The 2016 Standing Rock encampment -- in which thousands of water protectors from Lakota and other nations gathered to resist the Dakota Access Pipeline -- showed the world what the Lakota relationship with water (Mni Wiconi -- Water is Life) means in practice. It is not a slogan. It is a sacred declaration grounded in the specific understanding that water is a relative, not a resource -- that to contaminate it is to harm a living being, not merely damage an asset.

The contemporary He Sapa struggle continues: the \$2 billion uncollected in the US Treasury; the Sacred He Sapa Restoration Act drafted in 2024; Interior Secretary Deb Haaland's December 2024 mining ban on 20,500 acres of Black Hills watershed; the Pe'Sla drilling dispute; the LandBack campaign centered on the Black Hills as its most important

symbol. The Lakota people's refusal to accept monetary compensation for He Sapa -- over four decades, at an accumulating cost of now nearly \$2 billion in foregone compensation -- is the most sustained, most specific, and most costly sacred declaration made by any people in this library. The Black Hills are not for sale.

The Haligrity Lens -- Wakan Tanka and the Living Sacred Field

The Lakota tradition offers Haligrity the most operationally precise and most immediately applicable available ancient parallel to what the Haligrity tradition holds about the relationship between the practitioner and the sacred field they inhabit: Mitakuye Oyasin -- All My Relations -- as the most complete available single statement of the practitioner's cosmological position.

When the Lakota practitioner says "Mitakuye Oyasin" at the beginning of ceremony, at the opening of the sweat lodge flap, at the end of prayer -- they are not saying a greeting or a pleasant sentiment. They are making a specific cosmological declaration: that everything present -- the rocks, the water, the fire, the participants, the spirits, the ancestors, the animal nations -- is a relative with specific relational obligations running in both directions. To enter ceremony with "All My Relations" is to enter with full awareness of the web of sacred relationship that the ceremony is being conducted within.

The Haligrity practitioner who does not merely agree philosophically with "All My Relations" but who walks through the day with the specific awareness that the center of the universe is exactly where they are standing, in every moment, in every encounter -- is walking in the specific quality of sacred attention that the Lakota tradition calls wakan. Everything is wakan. Every encounter is an encounter with the sacred. Every relationship is a sacred ceremony. The Sun Dance was illegal for 95 years. The practitioners maintained it in secret the entire time. Mitakuye Oyasin. Grand Rising.